

21 UP ↑ RAJ CHENGAPPA

What Lies Beneath



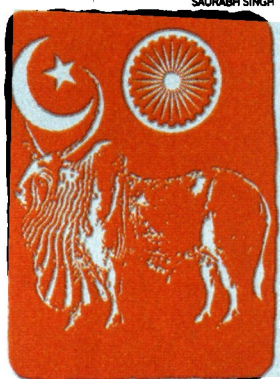
It was dark when we landed at Mohenjodaro airport and I was disappointed that we would not be able to see the most famous ruins that possibly every person who lives in the subcontinent has heard about. I was on my way to Pakistan to inter-

view among others Asif Zardari, the widower of Benazir Bhutto. As part of the mourning period, he was staying at her ancestral house in Naudero about 60 km from Mohenjodaro in Sindh Province. My flight back to Karachi from there was via Sukkur, a town in the opposite direction from Mohenjodaro. But no way was I going to miss seeing the fount of the Indus Valley Civilisation. So early next morning we drove right back to where the ruins lay preserved.

Indus Valley sites, unlike the Great Pyramids or Roman relics, have little or almost nothing above ground and therefore at first sight are not visually stunning. But it is what lies beneath the mounds of mud that have been excavated which is fascinating. They speak volumes of the glorious civilisation that existed. The history text-

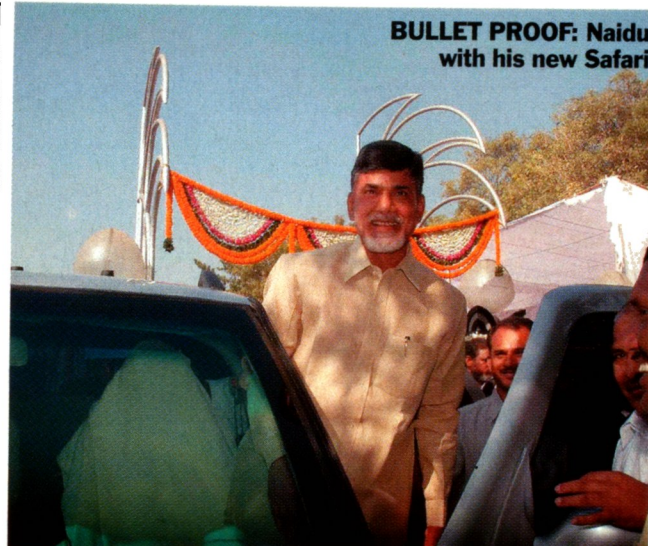
books I had read when I was in school had a very scratchy picture of the Great Bath. But for some reason it had left a lasting impression and I was very curious to see how it really looked. So as soon as we arrived I asked the guide to take us straight to it. Even after 4,500 years it is amazingly well preserved and I examined with wonder the two finely-fitted brick staircases that lead to it, the watertight floor with gypsum seals and the drains that lead to the cause-way. The streets of Mohenjodaro are straight as a ruler and orderly as are the way the main drains are laid. Everything was a marvel of civil engineering. It was apparent our ancestors lived well, with a great deal of cleanliness, intelligence and harmony.

Despite excavations beginning in the early 20th century (Mohenjodaro or the 'mound of the dead' was discovered only in the 1920s) mystery still surrounds the origin of the people of such an advanced civilisation. The script they wrote in is yet to be convincingly deciphered. After Independence, hundreds of so-called Indus sites have been excavated both in Pakistan and India, the most famous of them recently being Dholavira in Gujarat. History may have divided us but Pakistan and India are united by geography and a common heritage. It is important to remember this as we move with agonising slowness on the path to peace between the two countries.



SAURABH SINGH

A PRABHAKAR RAO



BULLET PROOF: Naidu with his new Safari

Hyderabad Blues

HYDERABAD With elections less than 15 months away, TDP supremo N. Chandrababu Naidu is bracing himself for a long road show. He has bought himself a new bullet-proof Tata Safari costing Rs 20 lakh after the state Government ignored his repeated demands for new vehicles to replace his ageing convoy of six Ambassadors which have already run over 2 lakh km. The former chief minister plans to buy five more Safaris.

Naidu's grudge is that in the last four years, Chief Minister Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy's convoy of vehicles has been changed twice. Reddy began with a fleet of silver Tata Safaris, which were replaced with black Mahindra Scorpios last year. Providing six new vehicles—including two bullet-proof cars to Naidu—would have cost the state exchequer a total of Rs 1 crore. Naidu had even written to the prime minister requesting new vehicles for his convoy but to no avail.

The state Government

had expressed its inability to cater to Naidu's request and had offered him a lone bullet-proof Scorpio. But the TDP contended that a Scorpio in a convoy with five old Ambassadors would stand out like a sore thumb, making Naidu vulnerable to attacks as his vehicle would be easily identifiable.

Naidu had escaped a bid on his life at Alipiri on October 1, 2003 when his sturdy bullet proof vehicle had withstood a landmine blast. He has been given a Z-Plus security cover of 30 personnel of the National Security Guards (including Black Cat commandos) and 134 policemen. His convoy includes one vehicle fitted with an electronic jammer while one serves as a decoy and the others carry his securitymen and associates.

Apart from shelling out a hefty sum for his convoy, Naidu is also toying with the idea of hiring a private security agency, something no other politician has done before.

by Amarnath K. Menon